JAMMU & KASHMIR

KASHMIR GETS A CLIMATE SCARE

By Kaleem Geelani

J&K and rain in the plains.

Till the reprieve that almost came too late, the drying up of water sources had been despairingly ubiquitous in Kashmir this winter. The springs and streams, including the tributaries of the Jhelum river that crisscross the Valley, were running dry. In the past few years, winters have been undergoing a shift in the western Himalayan region; according to the Indian Meteorological Department, this January-February, snow and rainfall decreased by 75 per cent, till some of it was recovered.

Jammu & Kashmir's economy is dependent on the agriculture and horticulture sector, which contributes to the livelihood of 70 per cent of locals. Farmlands and orchards, as per official records, cover 53 per cent of the Union territory's 42,241 sq. km of land. In 2023-24, the sector contributed 14.85 per cent to the UT's total gross state domestic product (GSDP) of Rs 2.41 lakh crore. For key crops like apples and paddy, the region relies heavily on canal irrigation, which sources its water from the springs and streams. Though the prolonged dry spell plaguing those sources is over, this late precipitation is unlikely to overturn the damage already done by the winter's accumulated deficit. Besides, there is the summer and the increasingly irregular monsoon rains to think of.

"We are preparing a contingency plan and considering options, including groundwater extraction and rainwater harvesting. The water-intensive paddy cultivation might have to be restricted," says Iftikhar Kakroo, chairman, Jammu and Kashmir Water Resources Regulatory Authority.

IN A DRY STATE

- **Till rains arrived in late February and saved the situation, J&K stared at a water crisis; snow and rainfall fell by 75 per cent this winter; rivers ran dry**
- **With 70 per cent of J&K's population dependent on agriculture and horticulture, the shortfall has everyone worried**
- **Decreasing rain from the monsoon, western disturbances is attributed to global climate change**
- **Hydel power generation also hit due to low water levels, a new action plan for climate change raises hope**



Water shortage had hit hydropower generation, too—pulling it down to an all-time low of 120-150 MW till late February out of a total installed capacity of 1,197 MW amongst 13 power projects managed by the Jammu and Kashmir Power Development Corporation Limited. What makes the situation worse is that the Indus Water Treaty between India and Pakistan prohibits the construction of reservoirs, allowing only the use of run-of-the-river for hydel power generation. With climate change tightening its grip, experts feel the need for reservoirs. "Water conservation and proper storage capacities become vital in times of crisis," says Sami Ullah Bhat, head of the Environmental Science department at the University of Kashmir. Climate scientists argue that the change in Kashmir's climate—a significant decrease in precipitation from the monsoon and western disturbances, too—is due to global climate change. "Himalayan Kashmir is the worst sufferer due to global climate change despite making no significant contribution towards it," Majid Farooq, coordinator of the climate change coordination cell at J&K's Ecology, Environment and Remote Sensing department, tells INDIA TODAY.

Almost 27 per cent of J&K is covered by forests, which makes it carbon-surplus. The trade of carbon credits, which would enable the UT to invest in climate-change mitigation, will have to wait till 2026, for the launch of the Indian Carbon Market.

After the launch of National Action Plan on Climate Change in 2008, J&K saw its first climate action plan in 2014 with a Rs 6,000-crore outlay, but many actions were allegedly unmet due to a fund deficit. However, a new Action Plan for Climate Change has been initiated. The plan, which is being revised after the publication of its draft in June 2024, proposes a financial outlay of Rs 66,600 crore. A lot depends on this and on allocation for environment in the March budget of the Omar government. ■